



History and humility: Two lessons from the knockouts

From fan intelligence to Jammu and Kashmir's historic leap, our reporters uncover **off-field moments** that defined the Ranji Trophy semifinals.

"Mithun, we have done it!" said coach Ajay Sharma with childlike excitement over a video call after Jammu and Kashmir upset Bengal by six wickets in the semifinal to enter its maiden Ranji Trophy final at the Bengal Cricket Academy ground in Kalyani.

On the other side of the call was Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) president and former J&K cricket administrator Mithun Manhas, who had made his Ranji debut for Delhi under Ajay's captaincy nearly three decades ago.

The 61-year-old Ajay was relieved. "I did not sleep for three nights. Tonight, I will," he said. His anxiety before the contest was understandable. It was a historic moment in J&K's 67-year-old cricketing journey — a rare positive occasion for which the region made the headlines.

With administrator Brig. Anil Gupta in command of the Jammu and Kashmir Cricket Association (JKCA), and coach Ajay and captain Paras Dogra in charge of the young team, mostly consisting of players in their mid-20s, the outfit thrived on self-belief and hard work. A motivational line — "I can. I will." —

written on their kit bags spoke of their keenness to excel.

In the historic semifinal, J&K played like a champion. Individually, Dogra achieved the milestone of becoming the second batter to score 10,000 runs, on his way to his first Ranji Trophy final, while pace ace Auqib Nabi, the highest wicket-taker of the season, claimed nine wickets and scored a crucial 42 to secure the Player-of-the-Match award.

"Nabi has been performing well for the last two years. And God has listened to him. Everybody wants to know 'Who is Auqib Nabi?' and he has shown 'I am Auqib Nabi.' Whatever he touches becomes gold. I hope he